

Spiritual Significance of Treaty Four/project

Law 353B: Aboriginal and Treaty Rights

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My spirit name is Quietly Sitting Bear Woman. My English name is Karen Osachoff and I am Cree/Saulteaux/Lakota from the Pasqua First Nation. My mother's name is Beverly Kahnpace and she is Cree/Saulteaux. My father's name is Lionel Obey and he is Cree/Lakota from the Piapot First Nation. Both of these reserves are located in Treaty Four Territory near Fort Qu'Appelle in Saskatchewan.

My paper and project is based on my past academic experience with the legal/written text of Treaty Four and the conflict between the different interpretations of Treaty from an oral/spiritual understanding of my Nation. While academically, I thought I understood Treaty Four and what it meant, through an oral history experience with my people and other Indigenous peoples, I have come to realize some of the depth and true meaning behind our treaty. Treaty Four to our people represents a relationship, a spiritual relationship that has not been broken over time, but continues to exist. What my ancestors agreed to in 1874 is still relevant today, in that we agreed to share the land with our settler brothers and (sisters), and we agreed that we would respect the way of life of the settlers but that reciprocally, our way of life would be not interfered with. Regardless of how colonization has unfolded, the intent of our ancestors has always existed, and while there may have been a long, painful, genocidal process that we had to go through, our people are still here, thriving and spiritually recovering.

A Lakota star blanket is traditionally made and given to honor someone or an experience, and to me, this blanket represents honoring my ancestors for their tremendous vision, fortitude and love as they signed Treaty Four. While the blanket is based on a traditional Lakota blanket, it is also my contemporary understanding of the treaty relationship. My experience in bringing this star blanket to life is much more significant than what can be seen. To begin the process, I approached a well respected woman in the community to help me, Gloria Larocque, whose expertise in sewing made the blanket come to life. The process of getting to know her, and see the care she put into this

project with me was overwhelming and beautiful because it felt like a spiritual process in itself to seek guidance from a traditional woman who knew how to sew. I also interviewed the Chief of my band, Elaine Chichoose, while she was in Vancouver doing a presentation on the Treaty land entitlement process our band has negotiated with the Federal government and Saskatchewan. While that process is a paper in itself, I was honored to speak with her, face to face and really talk about what our treaty meant and her spiritual understanding of treaty four.

What she told me is that her spiritual understanding of our Treaty is when we signed these sacred agreements; we signed them with trust, respect and our sacred pipe. While the written word about this aspect of the signing of treaty four disagrees with her assertions, she was adamant that Chief Pasqua had his pipe during the signing of Treaty and used it to guide him. Whether the pipe was used with Alexander Morris and party is another story. Either way, our Chief put his faith, trust and wisdom in signing our treaty, so the written text was the British record, and our oral history is ours. Our oral history says that we, the Treaty Four Nations, would maintain peace and friendship with the newcomers and share land as it was needed. The gratuities that were received on treaty signing day were a sign of respect, not a payout for our land. Our elders state that we did not agree to give away all the land. From a reasonable perspective, who would agree to such a thing?

My current Chief also stated that the main spiritual significance of our treaty is that we survived the brutal cultural and physical genocide that has been inflicted on us since Treaty signing. This has been a span of 133 years from beginning to present. In my family, it has been seven generations since Chief Piapot, my great-grandfather on my dad's side, signed Treaty Four. And while many of our family members have died from the effects of this genocide, there are still many of us left, coming back to our culture, getting higher education, and walking the red road. My Chief walks the red road and hopefully many more of our people will walk this road too. Her understandings of our Treaty rights are that because we signed this agreement with the right mind and the right heart,

and with Creator, this is the reason why our people survived and are now coming on the red road. Since this is what we originally wanted, our survival and flourishing are directly related to the signing of Treaty.

The colors I picked for this star blanket are the four colors that are used at sun dance. I picked them because they mean healing, gratitude, insight, cleansing of negativity and the red road. They also represent the four directions, and the four races. The four races being represented in this blanket is interesting too, because there are representatives of all four races in Treaty Four territory now. The orange burst in the center represents a contemporary understanding of our people, that we are bursting out from our colonial shackles and with the spiritual foundation of our treaty we will only flourish. **The original spirit and intent of treaty still exists!**

The band has also recently acquired a pictograph drawn by Chief Pasqua made at Treaty signing. The pictograph was taken by an English gentleman who kept it in his family for many generations until a private dealer bought it. This year it was bought from the dealer who had it in New York and it being held for our nation at the Royal Saskatchewan Museum. It is hoped that through direct observations and interpretations, more about treaty from the Chief's eyes will be revealed.

****I dedicate this project to the thousands of Treaty aboriginal people who have lost their lives in this country and their ancestors who are still here.**